Deep Learning Indaba𝕏
South Africa 2025

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Post-Event Report

1. Executive Summary

The 2025 edition of Deep Learning Indaba𝕏 South Africa, which took place in Stellenbosch on July 7-11, brought together a vibrant community of researchers, students, and industry practitioners from across South Africa and beyond. Using the attached registration, application, and travel-grant datasets, we can summarise the event as follows:

- **Strong demand:**
  - 423 completed applications for attendance.
  - 247 offers made, with 163 waitlisted and 13 rejected due to capacity constraints.
- **Actual participation:**
  - 359 unique participants on the Swapcard platform.
  - 328 attendees and 65 speakers (some speakers also registered as attendees).
  - 24 organisers supporting programme, logistics, and community-building (from organisers sheet).
- **Diversity & inclusion:**
  - Among accepted applicants, gender distribution was:
    - 55% men (135)
    - 44% women (109)
    - 1% non-binary / prefer not to say (3)
  - Applicants primarily from South Africa (≈91%) with 38 applicants from at least 20 other countries in Africa and Europe (including Rwanda, Botswana,

Namibia, Nigeria, Cameroon, Kenya, Tunisia, Zambia, Zimbabwe, Germany, France, Malaysia and others).

- **Access & financial support:**
  - 304 of 423 applicants (72%) indicated that they needed financial support (travel and/or accommodation) to attend.
  - 45 travel & accommodation grants were awarded.
  - Total travel/accommodation support disbursed:

    ~R99,780, with a mean award of ~R2,217, ranging from R580 to R5,000.
  - Approximately 89% (40 of 45) of travel-grant recipients were students (undergraduate, honours/graduate, or doctoral).
- **Research & programme activities:**
  - 53 research abstract submissions (talks and research presentations).
  - 234 participants indicated that they would bring posters, supporting a large and active poster session.
  - 32 invited speakers participated across technical talks, panels, and/or tutorials.
  - A very high level of interest in practical activities and hackathons: 319 of 423 applicants (75%) indicated they were interested in participating in the hackathon.

Funders' support was instrumental in enabling participation from under-resourced institutions and regions, supporting early-career researchers, and maintaining low barriers to entry while still delivering a high-quality, research-driven programme.

2. Event Objectives

The 2025 Indaba𝕏 South Africa was designed to:

1. **Grow and connect the South African machine learning community**, with a particular focus on students and early-career researchers.
2. **Strengthen links between academia and industry**, by inviting industry participants, speakers, and sponsors to engage with students and researchers.
3. **Enable equitable access** by lowering financial barriers to participation through travel and accommodation support.
4. **Showcase African research and talent** via talks, posters, and opportunities for networking and collaboration.

These objectives are reflected in the composition of applicants, the high proportion of students, the strong interest in hackathons and posters, and the structure of the financial support offered.

3. Participation & Reach

3.1 Applications and Selection

From the integrated applications table:

- Total applications: 423
- Outcomes (from the accepted/waitlist sheet):
    - 247 accepted
    - 163 waitlisted
    - 13 rejected

This means more than 1.7 applications for every place offered, highlighting significant and growing demand for Indaba𝕏-style events in South Africa.

3.2 Actual Attendance

Using the Swapcard attendee list:

- 359 unique people were registered on the event platform.

- 328 were tagged as Attendees (including speakers who also attended general sessions).
- 65 were tagged as Speakers or Attendees, or Speakers.

Combined with the organisers' list, this indicates a large, active community presence over the course of the event.

3.3 Academic vs Industry Participation

From the dedicated academic and industry registration forms:

- **Academic registrations:** 43 participants.
    - Representing at least 27 distinct academic institutions (universities, universities of technology, and research institutions).
- **Industry registrations:** 51 participants.
    - Representing at least 40 distinct companies and organisations, including both large corporates and smaller startups/consultancies.

This mix strikes a healthy balance between academia and industry, fostering opportunities for internships, collaborations, and recruitment.

4. Participant Profile

4.1 Career Stage

From the central application form ("Which of the following best describes you?"):

- MSc students: 128
- Undergraduate students: 113
- Honours students or equivalent: 67
- PhD students: 62
- Postdoctoral researchers: 4

So at least 374 of 423 applicants (≈88%) were students or postdocs, confirming that the event is strongly focused on early-career talent.

Additional categories:

- Academic professionals: 13
- Industry professionals: 11
- Independent researchers: 7
- Unemployed: 17
- High school students: 2

4.2 Geographic Distribution

From “What is your country of residence?” in the applications:

- South Africa: 385 applicants (≈91%)
- Other countries: 38 applicants (≈9%) across at least 20 distinct countries, including:
  - Rwanda (7), Botswana (5), Germany (3), Zimbabwe, Eswatini/Swaziland, Tanzania, Kenya, Lesotho, Namibia, Zambia, Tunisia, Cameroon, Nigeria, Egypt, Ghana, the DRC, France, Malaysia, and others (some with variant spellings).

This shows that while the event is predominantly South African, it attracts regional and international interest and is starting to function as a continental and global node for machine learning engagement.

4.3 Gender Balance

Among accepted participants (247):

- Men: 135 (54.7%)
- Women: 109 (44.1%)
- Non-binary: 2 (0.8%)

- Prefer not to say: 1 (0.4%)

This represents an unusually strong gender balance for a technical event, especially given the overall gender skew in the broader AI/ML field. Continued work is needed, but funder support directly contributes to sustaining this trend (e.g., by making participation more accessible to under-represented groups).

4.4 Skills & Experience

From the "Machine Learning level" question in the applications:

- Beginner/ Basic: ~209 applicants
- Intermediate: 144 applicants
- Advanced / Expert: ~64 applicants

In broad terms:

- ~50% described themselves as Beginner or Basic,
- ~35% as Intermediate, and
- <15% as Advanced or Expert.

This confirms that the Indaba𝕏 is successfully supporting newcomers and upskilling early-stage practitioners, not only serving a small, advanced group.

5. Programme, Research & Activities

5.1 Speakers & Sessions

From the speakers' registration sheet:

- 32 invited speakers across academia and industry.
- Topics span core ML, deep learning, optimisation, applications in health, finance, language and vision, as well as broader discussions on responsible AI and ecosystem-building (from "Topic of interest or abstract details" fields).

Speakers also consented to recruitment-related data sharing in many cases, which is valuable to sponsors and partners looking to engage with the talent pipeline.

5.2 Research Abstracts & Posters

From the abstracts and poster-related sheets:

- 53 research abstract submissions for talks.
  - Internal reviewer scoring ("Final Choice") shows strong enthusiasm to accept a majority of these (most rated "5 – Yes!" or "4 – Maybe Yes").
- 234 participants indicated that they would bring posters (from the consolidated poster sheet).

This created a substantial research showcase, giving students and early-career researchers a platform to present their work, receive feedback, and network with potential collaborators and employers.

5.3 Hackathon Interest

From the application form:

- 319 of 423 applicants (75%) indicated they were interested in participating in the hackathon.

This strong interest validates the continued inclusion of hands-on, project-based activities that allow participants to apply what they learn and collaborate in small teams.

6. Financial Access & Travel Support

Financial assistance was offered as follows:

- 45 travel/accommodation grant recipients.
- Total value of awards: R99,780.
- Average award: ~R2,217.
- Range: R580 – R5,000 per participant.

Career-stage breakdown:

- Graduate: 20
- Doctoral: 9
- Undergraduate: 8
- Other degree students: 3
- Working 0–5 years: 3
- Working 6–15 years: 1
- Working 15+ years: 1

Thus, around 89% (40 of 45) of travel-grant recipients were students, with the remainder being early-career professionals.

From the applications:

- 304 of 423 (≈72%) indicated that they needed some form of funding to attend (transport and/or accommodation).
- Only 119 (≈28%) reported that they could fully self-fund.

This demonstrates that funder support:

- Directly enabled dozens of participants to attend who otherwise would not have been able to; and
- Partially mitigated, but did not fully address, the high level of unmet financial need among applicants; an important datapoint for future fundraising targets.

7. Outcomes & Impact

Although comprehensive post-event surveys are not included in the attached files, the qualitative responses to “What I am hoping to get out of this event” (from the completed registrations) emphasise:

- **Networking and community:** Meeting other people working in ML and AI in South Africa and the wider region.
- **Learning and upskilling:** Gaining a deeper understanding of machine learning, deep learning, and their applications.
- **Research feedback:** Getting input on ongoing research projects, methods and problem formulations.
- **Career development:** Exploring internships, jobs, supervision, and collaboration opportunities.
- **Contribution back to the community:** Many respondents explicitly mention mentoring, tutoring, and building the local AI ecosystem.

Taken together with the participation data, the event:

- Strengthened the national ML/AI talent pipeline, particularly at the student and early-career level.
- Enabled cross-institutional and cross-sector connections, with dozens of academic and industry organisations represented.
- Provided concrete exposure opportunities to funders and sponsors, who were able to interact with a diverse pool of candidates.

8. Lessons Learned & Recommendations

Based on the data in the attached spreadsheets and the observed patterns:

1. **Demand exceeds current capacity**
    - With 423 applications and only 247 offers, the event is significantly oversubscribed.
    - Recommendation: explore larger venues, parallel tracks, or satellite/online components to accommodate more participants without diluting quality.8
2. **High unmet financial need**

- 304 applicants requested financial support; only 45 grants could be awarded (~15% of those in need).
- Recommendation: set a target to increase the travel & accommodation grant budget in future editions, with a particular focus on students from under-resourced institutions and more distant provinces/countries.

3. **Sustain and deepen gender balance and inclusion**
   - The gender ratio among accepted participants (≈45% women) is positive compared to sector norms.
   - Recommendation: maintain targeted outreach, mentorship, and funding support for under-represented groups, and track these metrics year-on-year.
4. **Leverage strong hackathon interest**
   - With 75% of applicants indicating hackathon interest, this is a clear differentiator of the event.
   - Recommendation: expand structured hackathon tracks, including industry-sponsored challenges and prizes, potentially co-designed with funders.
5. **Strengthen data flows for impact reporting**
   - The existing spreadsheets already provide rich insight.
   - Recommendation: standardise post-event feedback surveys and integrate them with registration data to quantify long-term impact (internships obtained, collaborations formed, publications, etc.).

9. Acknowledgements to Funders & Partners

The outcomes described in this report were only possible because of direct financial and in-kind support from funders and partners. In particular, funder contributions:

- Enabled R99,780 in travel and accommodation support, allowing students and early-career researchers from across South Africa and the continent to participate.

- Helped secure an outstanding lineup of 32 speakers from academia and industry.
- Supported the infrastructure needed to host 359 participants, dozens of research posters, and a strong programme of talks and activities.

Continued and expanded support will allow future editions of Deep Learning Indaba𝕏 South Africa to:

- Reach more participants in need of financial assistance,
- Offer richer technical and professional development content, and
- Sustain a thriving, diverse and globally connected African machine learning community.

END OF REPORT

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